

Spicy bean tamales

Traditional tamales are made with pork or beef, not to mention animal lard. This vegetarian version is relatively **easy** once you locate two key ingredients: masa harina, which is made from dried corn that is boiled in lime, then hulled and finely ground, and dried corn husks. Both can be found in Mexican specialty stores, *bodegas*, and many supermarkets.

Serve your tamales warm, topped with salsa or fresh guacamole and a salad or with rice and beans. A large bamboo steamer is ideal for this recipe or a two-steamer insert. I made the recipe easier by using organic canned beans but, as always, dried can be used if that is your preference.

16 dried cornhusks

1 teaspoon salt

Spicy Two-Bean Filling (recipe follows)

$\frac{1}{2}$ teaspoon freshly ground pepper

2 cups [250 g] fresh or frozen corn kernels

2 teaspoons maple syrup

1 cup masa harina [130g]

$\frac{1}{2}$ to $\frac{3}{4}$ cup water [125 to 150ml]

1 teaspoon baking powder

1. **Sort** through the cornhusks and pick out the largest ones; try to get them approximately the same size. Clean them of any debris, tie them with a string, and submerge completely in a bowl of warm water. Soak for about 1 hour, or until pliable. The recipe makes 8 tamales, but you'll want to have a few extra husks on hand in case you need to double-wrap some.
2. While the husks are softening, **prepare** the bean filling.
3. **Puree** the corn in a food processor. Add the masa harina, baking powder, salt, pepper, and maple syrup. Turn the machine on and gradually add enough water to form a thick paste, spreadable but not too loose.
4. Dry the softened cornhusks and begin to fill them as follows: **Spread** one out on a clean cutting board with the narrower end facing you. (If the husks are small, dou-

ble them up side by side, overlapping slightly and placing the narrow end of one next to the wide end of the other.) Spoon 2 generous tablespoons of corn filling on the upper third of the husk (toward the thicker end). With a butter knife, spread the filling into a rectangular shape, leaving a $\frac{3}{4}$ -inch [2-cm] margin around the top and sides and plenty of room on the bottom third of the husk. Line 1 tablespoon of bean filling down the middle of the corn mixture and gently roll or fold in the sides to form a cone shape. Fold the narrow end up over the seam.

5. **Arrange** the tamales, seam side down, in a steamer. Cover with extra husks and steam for about 1 hour. Let the tamales rest for 3 to 5 minutes before serving.

MAKES 8 TAMALES; SERVES 4

Spicy two-bean filling

1 small onion, minced	1 cup cooked or canned kidney beans [160g]
2 garlic cloves, minced	$\frac{1}{2}$ tablespoon chili powder or 1 teaspoon chipotle chile powder
$\frac{1}{2}$ fresh hot pepper (your choice), seeded and minced	2 teaspoons molasses
1 tablespoon olive oil	1 tablespoon coarsely chopped cilantro
1 cup cooked or canned adzuki beans [170g]	Salt and freshly ground pepper

Cook the onion, garlic, and hot pepper in the olive oil over low heat until soft, about 5 to 7 minutes. Add the adzuki and kidney beans and continue to cook for another minute or so. With a potato masher or large wooden spoon, **mash** the beans until about half are mashed (this should take only 2 or 3 mashes). Add the chili powder, molasses, and cilantro. Season with salt and pepper to taste.

MAKES ABOUT 2 $\frac{1}{2}$ CUPS [325ML]